



Anger and ASSERTION

A change that alters the political matrix is upon us: in the electoral politics of Muslims, fear of the future is replaced by existential angst

— By **M. J. AKBAR**

When does tomorrow begin? If it always began at midnight, we might be better able to prepare for it. The trouble with tomorrow is that it began so many yesterdays ago. How do you change yesterday in order to finesse towards a better tomorrow? Every yesterday pauses, and eventually comes to an end: that is the good news.

The politics of Islam should not be confused with the politics of Muslims. The former is the stuff of seminaries, although its consequences can seep on to the street. The most Indian instance is surely the rancorous—one must never underestimate the passions of doctors of doctrine—debate between

the Barelvis and Deobandis. Muslim politics moves on a different trajectory, which is why so often famous Indian maulvis seem to get left behind in the electoral race.

The most important Indian Muslim political movement, which culminated in the demand for Pakistan between 1940 and 1947, was led by a self-declared secularist, Mohammad Ali Jinnah, and opposed by the largest union of clerics, the Deoband-oriented Jamaat-e-Ulema. Jinnah cantered home to Pakistan after he swept the general elections of 1946. (He would have approved of the verb 'canter', since spending an afternoon at the Bombay race course was one of his preferred epicurean pleasures.)

At one level, the electoral politics of Indian Muslims in 2009 was propelled by the same

emotion as 1946: fear of the future. The context is not the same, so the consequences will obviously be different, but the existential angst is similar. In 1946, fear of the future meant fear of an India controlled by the Congress. In 2009 it was fear of an India controlled by the BJP. The Congress was considered as Hindu in 1946 as the BJP is considered today; the rhetoric of many Muslim League leaders was far more vicious than anything heard today.

However, if that were the only narrative about Muslim politics it would be interesting but not quite a story. The predictable placidity of continuity is giving way to the excitement of divergence. The change is shaping the future of the east, Bengal, Bihar and Assam, where different experiments are in process to lift Indian